Compatibility Concerns

QUESTION OF THE MONTH

Q I have heard that SATA II hard drives may be incompatible with some older SATA I motherboards. I want to buy a hard drive, and I have a SATA I compatible motherboard. Should I go for a SATA I or a SATA II drive?

Biju Thomas

A The SATA II standard is supposed to be backward-compatible, but you should keep in mind that there do exist a few compatibility issues. Some motherboards that use early versions of Via's K8T880 chipset don't work well with some SATA 3 Gbps drives. Newer chipsets have solved these problems. Because of some of the early incompatibilities, some SATA 3 Gbps (SATA II) drives are actually shipped in 1.5 Gbps (SATA I) mode. You may require a utility available from the manufacturer's Web site to let you set the drive to the faster mode.

For example, Hitachi Global Storage Technologies, manufacturer of the Deskstar line of SATA drives, offers the Feature Tool on the company's download site (**www.hitachigst.com/hdd/support/download.htm**).

It's available in three forms, all of which create bootable media, since the utility works only as a standalone app. Some drives, such as those from Samsung and Western Digital, have jumpers for this purpose. Back up your drive before using any utility that can modify hard drive settings.

Keyboard Kaput?

Q I hear faint "beep" sounds as I tap keys on my keyboard. If I need to type in a word that has a letter that repeats consecutively, I have to pause a few seconds before repeating the letter. I even replaced my keyboard, but to no avail. This is getting very frustrating—what can I do?

Kiran Chedda

A The Accessibility feature in Windows is intended to aid users with physical difficulties in using the keyboard. Accessibility has a feature called FilterKeys that helps such users—when FilterKeys is active, Windows ignores rapidly repeated keystrokes, and drastically slows down the repeat rate. This is similar to what you've described. It looks like you've accidentally activated this feature by keeping the [**Shift**] key pressed for eight seconds and then clicking OK.

To turn off FilterKeys, launch Accessibility Options from the Control Panel. Uncheck the box titled Use FilterKeys, then click the Settings button. Near the top is a box titled Use Shortcut: uncheck it. While you're at it, also turn off StickyKeys, the option for which is also in the Accessibility Options. This is another feature that can be troublesome if you don't need it. Click OK twice to finish restoring normal keyboard operation.

When PCs Go Bad

Q I've recently bought a high-end PC, and it was performing flawlessly until now. But for the past few days, it has started rebooting spontaneously. This happens mostly during CPU and graphics-intensive applications such as gaming or video rendering. How can I fix this?

Ravi Patil

A Frequent reboots during intensive operations are most likely due to a hardware problem. There are several possible causes. You will need to check your PC in the following order.

First, the PC may be overheating due to dust accumulation. Over time, dust can gather inside the PC cabinet, layering over heat sink surfaces, memory modules, and circuit boards. You can blow the dust out with something as simple as an air blower.

Turn off your PC and disconnect it from the mains. Discharge yourself of any static by grounding yourself and rubbing your hands on a metal surface, open the case, and check to see where dust has accumulated. Be sure to use short bursts with the air blower, and also clean the surface of the cooling fans mounted on the CPU and GPU heat sinks.

Another possible cause is a problem with the power supply. You might have exceeded the power supply's capacity to deliver adequate power to the graphics card.

Or it may simply be that the power supply is failing.

Yet another cause could be memory going bad. This can be easily tested by downloading a free copy of Memtest86+ (**www.memtest.org**). Run Memtest from a bootable floppy or CD. It will run a series of tests on your system memory to check if it is failing.

Get Help Now!

E-mail us your computing problems along with your contact details and complete system configuration to **sos@jasubhai.com**, and we might answer them here! Since we get many more mails per day than we can handle, it may take some time for your query to be answered. Rest assured, we are listening!

Pinpointing A Power Problem

Q My old power supply recently failed, and I just got myself a new one. The problem is that my older power supply was a 20-pin type, and the new one has a 24-pin connector. My motherboard only has 20 pins for the main power connector. What do I do now?

Gerlin George

A You can plug the 24-pin connector into the 20-pin socket on your motherboard. It will go in only one way, and four pins will go unused.

In addition to the wider power supply connector, all motherboards now have an auxiliary 4-pin power connector socket that dedicates power for the CPU. If your motherboard has one such socket, don't forget to plug that one in as well—your new power supply will have the required connector.

We'd like to tell you that the 20-pin connector common in ATX 2.0 power supplies is being slowly replaced by the 24-pin connector. You can also plug a 20-pin, ATX 2.0 power supply into a 24-pin motherboard socket, but it's not recommended, since it cannot provide adequate power for CPU-intensive applications.

The greater power draw of modern CPUs can mean instability if insufficient power is delivered.■